

Relapse, Recovery, Transformation

This is a truth so write it down. Whatever you give to God on earth He will more than give back to you in heaven.

Let me talk to you about what Jesus said you should do with treasure. Perhaps Jesus' most familiar teaching on treasure is found in the Sermon on the Mount:

"Do not lay up for yourselves treasures on earth, where moth and rust destroy and where thieves break in and steal; but lay up for yourselves treasures in heaven."
Matthew 6:19-20

If you grew up in church you may assume that these verses mean spiritual pursuits are more important than earthly ones. But Jesus was talking about actual treasure and how you can keep it. He used the same word to describe real treasure on earth and real treasure in heaven (translated thesaurus in Greek). He didn't reveal what treasure in heaven would look like or how it would be measured, but it will be highly valuable.

Suppose your accountant said to you: "If you invest your treasure in Bank A, you will lose it. But if you invest treasure in Bank B, you will save it."

You'd never assume that while your accountant referred to your hard-earned money when she mentioned Bank A, she meant only your spiritual treasures when she recommended Bank B! Why, then, should we think that eternal treasure will be anything less than real and highly desirable?

Here in just one verse (Matthew 6:20), Jesus shatters three common misconceptions about how we should think about treasure:

1. What you should do with your treasure-"lay up." The Greek verb, translated "lay up," is in the imperative in this verse-it's Jesus' command. He wants you to know that laying up treasure is God's plan for you and is a directive you should obey.
2. Who you should lay it up for-"yourselves." Each of us must lay up treasure individually. Jesus reveals that if you don't lay up treasure for yourself in heaven, no one can do it for you. That's why Jesus called the man who never laid up treasure for himself a "fool" (Luke 12:13-21). Jesus never rewards selfishness, only selflessness. As you're going to see, to lay up treasure for ourselves in heaven, we must first give it to others on earth.
3. Where you should lay it up-"in heaven." Location matters if you lay up treasure on earth, as Jesus pointed out, it's vulnerable to corruption or loss.

The truth is that heaven is the only place where your treasure will be safe. By now you might be asking, "But why would treasure matter to me in heaven?" I understand the question. Yet we have to conclude from Jesus' dramatic statements here and elsewhere that our treasure will matter greatly to us in eternity!

In God's kingdom, when the sinful full of greed, envy, and manipulation is absent, we will enjoy our treasure, and it will serve a pure and meaningful purpose. As we'll see, our treasure will allow us to serve, to give, to accomplish, and to enjoy more for Him. But there's something very specific we must do, Jesus said, to "transfer" our treasure to heaven.

First of all let's define relapse. The word is only used twice and that is in the NASB. But you and I really need to understand that it in essence is just simply returning to sin. The bible deals with addiction as a sin originating in the heart. Drunkenness, idolatry, and sin are words the Lord uses to describe what the world only recently began calling "addiction". Now, for one to relapse, a person has to have first attained sobriety for a period of time. Someone who never achieved a sober period of time and continues to use and abuse drugs or any type of addictive pleasure is not relapsing. They are still in active addiction. However, one who has achieved a significant period of sobriety and returns back to the addictive pleasure has relapsed.

A biblical proverb aptly describes relapse in this manner: "the dog returns to its own vomit, and the sow, after washing herself, returns to wallow in the mire" (2 Peter 2:22b). After experiencing the freedom of a sober lifestyle, a person who relapses is choosing to return to the voluntary slavery of addiction. The word relapse is defined as the act or an instance of backsliding, worsening, or subsiding. Most people think that it is purely a physical problem when in reality it is a spiritual problem of the soul. Addiction is not merely a physical problem altered by medicine but a spiritual problem in the heart, or inner person. In fact, every individual is solely responsible to God to make right choices! This is a spiritual track that everyone must resign themselves to with a sincere dedication to God who can they want to please because they love him ALONG WITH stopping the behavior, or it cannot be sustained-you know why?? Because it is God that helps you stop it and His power is the only power that can keep it sustained!

What is Sin? It is not only what you are doing that is wrong but also includes what you are failing to do! Anything that comes between me and God is an idol-anything! D.L. Moody.

Ultimately we all are going to answer to God in the next life for what we choose to do in this one. The little choices we make have big, eternal consequences. Remember the treasures I spoke of earlier? In Luke 16:1-13, Jesus taught a parable that concluded with: "One who is faithful in a very little is also faithful in much, and one who is dishonest in a very little is also dishonest in much. Jesus was talking about the stewardship of money in terms of how temporal decisions in this life indicate whether a person will be faithful with eternal riches. The choices a person makes with temporary wealth will reveal the priorities in his heart regarding

eternal things. Jesus went further to say in verse 13, "No servant can serve two masters, for either he will hate the one and love the other, or he will be devoted to the one and despise the other. You cannot serve God and money."

Likewise in a relapse the choice a person makes to satisfy a temporal pleasure reveals a momentary loss of eternal perspective. All relapses involve a decision to live for the moment without regard for the far-reaching consequences and damage in this life and in the life to come. The reputation of God is damaged when a Christian makes a temporal choice deciding to relapse.

When you consider that the word of God declares a relapse to be sin, then you see that it is a choice to satisfy a temporary desire that you have already declared to be dangerous to your own well-being, the well being of others and damaging to the reputation of God. That relapse may be motivated by the desire to avoid pain or to seek pleasure, but, in either case, it is often sinful. Drunkenness, sexual immorality, and gluttony are sins. They are acts of the will for which every person is accountable to God.

The word of God calls sin a willful choice to disobey and not trust God. Disobeying God is always rooted in doubting God and not trusting Him. Many who sin think that they will get away with it. They are willing to risk the consequences just to achieve a temporary pleasure, or high. What about you?

OK. Now why am I going through the definition so deeply and talking about where it is rooted so much? Because look, if we have a physical problem, we go to the doctor. We don't go to the mechanic or call up at&t customer service right? No. And you may have thought, well I've got addiction in my life and that's a problem that there is not just stores like retail stores out there that pop up in these strip centers where you can just pull in and grab some sobriety. But you may think no Pastor-when someone has an addiction problem with drugs or alcohol or both, they go to a rehab. Well if that was true-if that was where you go to solve that problem, then many of you would have solved your addiction issues years ago. So raise your hands if you went to a rehab before coming here. Yeah and it didn't work obviously or you wouldn't be here-and I wouldn't have come to a teen challenge either. So, there has to be something different that you have to get hold of here and with a clear understanding of what relapse is, then you have a real chance of how to prevent it.

Newsflash: this is a spiritual problem-so if we don't fight it spiritually, we will not make it.

Addiction is a choice problem and addiction is a sin problem. Oswald Chambers said sin is blatant mutiny against God. When we entertain sin, we have almost already vacated God's protection and favor.

While it does have physical elements, an addiction is really a choice of your will to obey the flesh and deny the commands of the Holy Spirit. Addiction is a choice

problem in your will that causes you to be enslaved physically and emotionally to the idolatrous pleasure. For Christians, there is a war waging between their old nature characterized by the flesh, and their new nature characterized by the indwelling Holy Spirit. Galatians 5:16-17 puts it this way: now go there in your bible with your pen. "But I say, walk by the Spirit and you will not gratify the desires of the flesh. For the desires of the flesh are against the Spirit, and the desires of the Spirit are against the flesh, for these are opposed to each other, to keep you from doing the things you want to do." Now that is put so simply yet so deeply-look at this. I've always told you that once you start doing what you should do and stop doing what you always want to do, you will change your life. Lets read the last verse over again.....

Now some people mistakenly think that once you become a Christian sin is no longer a problem, but the opposite is actually true. The enemy of your soul will not be content to leave you alone. The difference between a Christian who sins and an unbeliever who sins is that the Christian feels badly about his sinful choices. This bad feeling as many often call it is actually a good thing called conviction and it is from the holy spirit. This conviction is meant to bring about change commonly called repentance. God wants to bring us to our knees in repentance, prayer, bible reading, and obedience to Him because He knows that conviction will ultimately bring obedience to Him because he knows that conviction will ultimately bring him glory and transform us into His image. Consider just one aspect of the holy spirit's role in the lives of men according John 16:7-9: "nevertheless I tell you the truth: it is to your advantage that I go away, for if I do not go away, the Helper will not come to you. But if I go, I will send him to you. And when he comes, he will convict the world concerning sin and righteousness and judgment: concerning sin, because they do not believe in me." Jesus is telling his disciples that he must go away but that he will send the helper, the holy spirit to come and the holy spirit will bring conviction of sin. That is simply one function of the holy spirit in our lives: to bring conviction of sin.

The next step is to understand that trusting yourself more than you trust God will ruin you if continued. I'm talking to everyone under the sound of my voice because that is the most truthful statements and it hits everyone at every level because ruin has many different definitions depending on where you are-ruin is different to everyone but it is possible if they start trusting themselves more than God.

Transformation vs Recovery

Our goal for our students is to help them to grow in new relationships and build new habits of thinking, speaking, and acting so that they never go back to addictive behavior. They must understand biblical words and concepts and reject the ideas of the world. Words have meaning and when scripture says "the Word became flesh" it identifies Jesus as the physical manifestation of the Word of God. In fact, words are so important that God used His words to create the world in which we live. Jesus did not live in an era of cameras and pictures, wants us to value His word not

pictures or symbols of Him! His words are to live within us as he himself is living within us. According to John 15:7: "if you abide in me, and my words abide in you, ask whatever you wish, and it will be done for you." That's powerful and I've learned cause I went through it as many of you have-its true.

One of the most profound mysteries in all of science is the way a caterpillar is transformed into a butterfly. This once and for all process, metamorphosis, can be likened to the transformation that occurred in the Apostle Paul, who was transformed like few others in history. You know the story....

Romans 12:2 states: "Do not....

One of the central messages of Christianity is that God wants us to "be transformed" into a new creation in Christ Jesus. Second Corinthians 5:17 states...therefore, if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation....." Note that this transformation is both an immediate occurrence at salvation (2 Cor 5:17) and an ongoing process of growing in Christ after salvation (Romans 12:2). Because of habitual sin, you must be transformed daily by the power of the Holy Spirit who renews your mind.

The command in scripture to be transformed applies to all people struggling with addiction problems. The Lord wants us to be transformed from being an addict and it applies to being addicted to anything really into being like His Son. In other words your identity is in Christ if you are a Christian, and your purpose is found only in the Word of Christ.

Recovery is the buzz-word in secular addiction counseling. Recovery means to regain or to recapture one's old self. For physical healing, recovery is a good word, for it implies an improvement in your condition. For spiritual healing, however, we find a better word in the Word of God. Scripture teaches that God desires more for than recovery or that we recapture our old self, because even when we recover our old self, we are left with just that-our old self. God desires a total transformation.

To transform something is to change its "character or condition." Even the word reform is inadequate for what God desires to do in an addict's heart because to reform something is simply to change into an improved form or condition. Again reform is a good word. But for the Christian God wants more. God wants transformation. He wants you to experience His transforming power to make you more like Christ and an entirely new creation.

2 Cor 3:18 and we all....are being transformed into the same image from one degree of glory to another. For this comes from the Lord who is the Spirit."

A transformation is God's answer for any and all types of "addiction." It is a lifelong process that begins when you are no longer thinking like the world, but thinking about and viewing life correctly-as God thinks about and views it-as revealed in HIS BIBLE.

Mercy is not receiving the punishment for our sins like death-for the wages of sin is death. But the gift of God is eternal life through Christ Jesus our Lord. And grace is unmerited or undeserved favor right? Well God's grace is given to undeserving sinners, even those who have relapsed! Romans 5:8 gives us another glimpse into the grace of God while we were still sinners, Christ died for us." In other words, we do not get right and then experience the grace of God, but rather, it is the opposite: we are wrong and receive the grace of God while we are yet sinners. So do not think you must get right from your relapse and then go to God. People are to Him now through a prayer of repentance, confessing your sins and asking Him to empower you to overcome your sin of addiction.

Relapse Prevention- 2 Types: Character Relapse prevention and what I call positional relapse prevention.

To prevent relapse, you must adopt God's character (and mind). You must think thoughts that are like His thoughts. Sadly, there are five very dangerous mindsets in addictive thinking that lead to patterns of living for self. Someone who is in an active addiction is labeled an addict, but he is actually a person who is focused upon pleasing self and willing to sin to do so.

So how does an addict think and act? He is living to please himself and is fulfilling the desires of his own flesh. When we begin biblically counseling someone coming out of active addiction, we can count on the person thinking in five particular ways: an entitlement mentality, a consumer mentality, a victim mentality, a perishing mentality, and a rebellious mentality. We call these mentalities because they are a predominant way of thinking about life. A mentality is defined as a mode or way of thought that affects one's outlook on life. It is a view of the world that colors the perceptions of a person and leads to interpretations of the world consistent with that view.

What is interesting about these five mentalities is that each one builds upon the previous mentality. If you observe an addict you will begin to see the entitlement and consumer mentalities manifest. The addict begins thinking he deserves better than what he is receiving (entitlement) and he consumes whatever he has upon himself (consumer). Next, you will see a victim mentality begin to emerge. The addict is now thinking that he is a victim of neglect or unfair treatment when a family member or friend does not give him his every desire. Note that the addict feels entitled and lives like a consumer; therefore, unmet desires frustrate him because he is living to please himself but is unable to do so. Rather than blame himself, he blames everyone else including God. Family members are perceived as harsh because the addict has an entitlement and consumer mentality.

Next, the addict who is now thinking like a victim will develop a perishing mentality. This new mindset is mired in self-pity, focusing his thoughts too much on himself in terms of what he does not have: "Bad things always happen to me." This attitude is actually a lack of gratitude that leads to despondent thinking, feeling sorry for

oneself, and self-destructive actions. In the final stage, the addict who now thinks with a perishing mentality begins thinking and acting like a rebel. Why should I try to do right or please anybody or please God?" says the addict who manifests the rebellious mentality. The end result is a rebellious, angry, and foolish acting person who seeks to be independent-to be free from any rules, laws, or restrictions. The addict wants to be his own boss at all costs.

These mentalities are understood clearly in light of the following two passages of Scriptures:

Matthew 22:37-40: and he said to him, "You shall love the lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your mind (opposite of entitlement). This the great and first commandment. And a second is like it: You shall love your neighbor as yourself (opposite of consumer). On these two commandments depend all the Law and the Prophets"

Ephesians 5:18-21: And do not get drunk with wine, for that is debauchery, but be filled with the Spirit, (opposite of victim) addressing one another in psalms and hymns and spiritual songs, singing and making melody to the Lord with all your heart, giving thanks always and for everything to God the Father in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ (opposite of perishing) submitting to one another out of reverence for Christ (opposite of rebellious).

The perishing mentality is a destructive way to think. This mindset develops in two ways. When a person focuses upon past hurts so much that they become the center of his universe, the perishing mentality develops quickly. Bringing glory to Jesus Christ must be our main focus and not unforgiven hurts from the past. That is a wrong response to being wronged! 1 Thess 5:15 states: "See that no one repays anyone evil for evil, but always seek to do good to one another and to everyone."

A perishing mentality may also develop when a person focuses upon what he does not have rather than on what he does possess eternally in Christ. It is a sinful, ungrateful way to think especially when one has been given eternal life through the forgiveness of Christ. The perishing mentality is mired in self-pity. Self-pity is prideful because it involves too much focus upon yourself and what you are not getting. It is based upon "I am not getting what I deserve and I deserve a whole lot better than this!" The truth is that God is very gracious to us since we all deserve eternal punishment in hell for our sins; but because of Jesus, we are forgiven and spared from what we really deserve.

Repentance from sin is a gift from God 2 Timothy 2:25. It is the kindness and patience of God that should lead us to repentance according to Romans 2:4.Or do you presume on the riches of his kindness and forbearance and patience, not knowing that God's kindness is meant to lead you to repentance?" Repentance is living God's way in obedience to Him and fills us with all kinds of spiritual blessings. Ask God to grant you the gift of repentance.

The great news is that all five of these mentalities have an opposing mentality that pleases God and achieves His purposes. As a person who wants to prevent relapse, you want to learn to think biblically so that you are less prone to turn to any “addiction.” In other words, transformed thinking enables you to know God, know what pleases Him, and to live a life that will be of great benefit to you and God’s kingdom.

As transforming Christians, everything hinges upon our thinking and mind renewal. In fact, as transforming Christians we are all called to think, speak, and act in the following five new replacement mentalities: be humble, be giving, be responsible, be grateful, and be submissive. Each of these is the opposite one of the five detrimental mentalities mentioned first. Here is a diagram to help you:

Put Off

Entitlement Mentality
Consumer Mentality
Victim Mentality
Perishing Mentality
Rebellious Mentality

Put On (be Transformed)

Be Humble
Be Giving
Be Responsible
Be Grateful
Be Submissive

God commands us to submit to Him in the first commandment: “You shall have no other gods before Me” Exodus 20:3. Then, authority is emphasized on a human level as it begins in the home according to the Fifth Commandment: “Honor your father and mother...” Exodus 20:12. Submission is an essential concept for the betterment of society and the betterment of a human being. People who fail to submit end up injured in the hospital, imprisoned, in jail, or dead in the grave. *Being submissive and servant-minded is the key to overcoming a rebellious mentality.*

Pride is the hindrance to being servant minded. Pride feeds a rebel’s heart.

Submission is the willful placement of our self under an authority. Submission literally means to yield ourselves to the will of another. It can also be called surrender.

We should remind ourselves daily that God is our Owner. He created us. He redeemed us by the blood of Christ. Therefore, He owns us and He is a good master. Its not like we are submitting to an evil person!

Satan wants to tempt you to be your own boss like he tempted Adam and Eve in Genesis 3:5: “for God knows that when you eat of it your eyes will be opened, and you will be like God, knowing good and evil.” Satan wants you to believe you can be your own god, not required to answer to anyone. Revelation 20:12 tells us that we will give an account to God in eternity: {and I saw the dead, great and small,

standing before the throne, and books were opened. Then another book was opened, which is the book of life. And the dead were judged by what was written in the books, according to what they had done.”

Simplify your relapse prevention strategy. Simply work on becoming humble, giving, responsible, grateful and submissive in your spirit. Review Matthew 22:37-40 and Ephesians 5:18-21 to help you remember this new way to be human! Don’t try to do too much. Rather, focus upon your own thinking, speaking, and actions. If you are concerned that you cannot do this without help, then that is a good place to be! You need the help of others so do not attempt to prevent relapse or be transformed alone.

So how do you prevent a relapse? Just say no? Is that all there is to it: just saying no to drugs and alcohol? Of course not! The real answer is that you must learn to say “yes to Christ. Saying “yes” to Christ is how the Holy Spirit will transform you as you learn to trust and obey God’s Word and all of His commands. In order to prevent a relapse from occurring, you must be transformed by the renewing of your mind Romans 12:2. Which will happen gradually in your life as you obediently practice thinking, speaking, and doing what is right, even in the little things. A person who wants to prevent relapse has integrity-which means doing the right thing when no one is watching. “Practice makes perfect” is a cliché but the truth is that practicing righteousness in thoughts, words, and actions makes one like the perfect Person, Jesus Christ.

God has two goals for you. First, He wants you to glorify Him 1 Corinthians 10:31. In other words, He wants you to make Him look good to a lost and dying world. He wants to be known and He works through you to reveal His true character to a sinful, fallen, polluted, and corrupted world ruined by mankind’s sin. Second, God wants to change you and make you more like His son (Romans 8:29). Most people really do not want to change. They are comfortable where they are, but the Lord wants you to be transformed into a new creation. Adopt His goals and implement them in your life in every way.

You will never say no until you have a bigger yes. In other words, you will never say no to sin until you say yes to righteousness, or making godly choices. Christians have no excuse because they can say yes to Christ through the power of the Holy Spirit who lives within a believer (2 Timothy 1:14) according to Philippians 2:13: for it is God who works in you, both to will and to work for His good pleasure.” Be encouraged that Christ is sufficient and His Word works in partnership with the Holy Spirit to bring about real, lasting and eternal change in the hearts of His people. The life of a devoted Christ-follower is exciting, fruitful, and powerful when the Holy Spirit is in charge.